

Chapter 6

Save Smarter, Not Harder

While there are many purchases we can say a complete “no” to, there are those physiological needs we can’t totally opt out from. While we need to buy them, we’ll often use their necessity as an excuse to overspend on them. Without a clear-cut “no” drawing the line between what you do and don’t value, it’s really hard to figure out what to spend on these foundational expenses.

I (Jen) went into my last car purchase as prepared as I could be. I did my research, made sure I was only looking at the best makes and models from the last three to five years, and knew which dealer fees were required and which ones could be negotiated. I narrowed it down to two cars. One I was excited about, the other was just to say I didn’t buy the first car I test-drove. They were the same price online, but one had lower mileage and the other had more premium features, and I really wanted adaptive cruise control. After test-driving the feature-laden car I intended to purchase, I sat down to negotiate. I knew about how much I could get shaved off the price, but what I was not expecting were all the additional dealer fees. They even charged me a fee because my trade-in was over five years old! I negotiated the price for three hours and got them down quite a bit. But there were still so many fees they were unwilling to budge on. The longer I sat there, the more I felt I owed to the guy working with us. He was so nice and was trying everything he could. After three hours I was exhausted, late to pick up my son, and just wanted to be done. I had my heart set on this adaptive cruise control. I had the pen in my hand to sign the deal and realized the quote I